Mississippi's Literacy Gains

Lessons Learned and Skepticism

Research Report | April 12, 2026

Executive Summary

Mississippi's 2013 Literacy-Based Promotion Act (LBPA) and the broader reading reform ecosystem it inaugurated are the most-studied state-level literacy reform of the past decade. Between 2013 and 2019, Mississippi climbed from 49th to 29th on 4th-grade NAEP reading, the largest gain in the country. By 2024, the state posted the highest demographically adjusted 4th-grade reading scores in the nation, ranked 9th outright, and recorded the largest long-term gains of any state.

The policy is a bundle: K-3 universal screening, LETRS-based teacher training, job-embedded literacy coaches, K-3 intervention, summer reading camps, and a high-stakes third-grade retention gate with 'good cause' exemptions. The state invested roughly $15 million per year (about $32 per K-3 pupil) on top of a $100 million private anchor from the Barksdale Reading Institute. Peer-reviewed and working-paper estimates place the aggregate treatment effect at roughly 0.14 standard deviations on 4th-grade NAEP reading, rising to 0.25 SD for cohorts exposed from kindergarten. Retention explains roughly 22 percent of the effect; coaching, training, and screening explain the rest.

Skepticism is legitimate and growing. Retention mechanically removes the lowest-performing students from the 4th-grade NAEP cohort, inflating the headline score by an amount researchers estimate at roughly one-quarter of the gain. Gains fade into 8th grade: Mississippi ranks 8th in 4th-grade reading and 42nd in 8th-grade reading. Black and low-income students are retained at higher rates, a pattern that cost Michigan its parallel law in 2023. A large-scale IES study found LETRS training improved teacher knowledge without moving student reading scores. And the 'miracle' framing obscures a decade of multi-lever work that cannot be replicated by simply passing a retention law.

For Tennessee, and for small districts like Greeneville City Schools, the practical lesson is narrower than the headlines: structured-literacy-plus-coaching works when implemented with fidelity over 5-10 years. The retention gate is a diagnostic nudge, not the engine. Districts should plan for middle-grade fade-out, monitor equity in retention and exemption decisions, and resist compliance-only models that purchase curriculum without investing in coaching and principal walkthroughs.

1. Definition & Background

The 'Mississippi Miracle' refers to Mississippi's 2013-2024 climb in 4th-grade NAEP reading following the Literacy-Based Promotion Act of 2013. The reforms layered on roughly 15 years of prior infrastructure. In 2000, Jim and Sally Barksdale gave $100 million to establish the Barksdale Reading Institute (BRI), which funded phonics-based reading coaches in 50+ high-need schools and seeded the Mississippi

Principal Corps (Mississippi Today, 2025; Magnolia Tribune, 2022). LBPA then codified, scaled, and state-funded what BRI had proven.

Core components of the LBPA and its implementing rules include: three-times-per-year universal K-3 literacy screening; Individual Reading Improvement Plans (IRIPs) with mandatory parent notification; two years of LETRS (Language Essentials for Teachers of Reading and Spelling) training for K-3 teachers; MDE-deployed literacy coaches assigned to the lowest-performing schools; summer reading camps; and the third-grade promotion gate requiring proficiency on the reading portion of the state assessment or a good-cause exemption (MDE; ExcelinEd, 2019). The policy was modeled on Florida's 2002 test-based retention law, which had produced short-term reading gains in the Greene & Winters (2007) and Schwerdt, West & Winters (2017) causal literature.

Mississippi's reforms are frequently labeled 'science of reading,' which generally means instruction grounded in the five National Reading Panel pillars of phonemic awareness, phonics, fluency, vocabulary, and comprehension, taught sequentially and systematically (NRP, 2000; Ehri et al., 2001). 'Structured literacy' is the Orton-Gillingham-aligned variant most often operationalized in state mandates. These frameworks are now codified in What Works Clearinghouse practice guides (Foorman et al., 2016) and in roughly 40 state K-3 screening statutes.

2. Evidence of Effectiveness

The causal evidence base on Mississippi's reforms is unusually strong for a state-level policy bundle. Spencer (2024, Economics of Education Review) uses synthetic difference-in-differences and estimates that LBPA raised 4th-grade NAEP reading scores by approximately 0.14 SD (about 5 scale-score points), with a similar spillover in math. For cohorts exposed since kindergarten, effects grew to 8 points in reading and 9 points in math. Spencer's decomposition attributes only about 22 percent of the effect to retention; the remainder reflects training, coaching, and screening/intervention.

Westall and Cummings (2023) analyzed 41 states with early literacy policies, finding 4-5 point 4th-grade NAEP gains in states adopting 'comprehensive' policies (screening + intervention + retention + coaching + professional learning) and no gains in states adopting partial policies. The comprehensive-policy gain attenuates by 8th grade, a consequential finding for replicators.

Slungaard Mumma and Winters (2023, Wheelock Policy Center) ran a regression discontinuity on Mississippi's 2014-15 3rd-grade cohort. Students barely retained under the rule scored more than 1.0 SD higher in 6th-grade ELA than barely-promoted peers. Effects were driven by Black and Hispanic students, with no impact on math, attendance, or special education identification. The effect is among the largest in the retention literature and directly replicates the positive pattern Schwerdt, West, and Winters (2017) found on Florida's law.

Component-level effect sizes

Intervention	Study	Design	Outcome	Effect Size
LBPA overall	Spencer (2024)	Synthetic DiD	Grade 4 NAEP	0.14 SD; ~8 pts for

			reading	K-exposed cohort
Comprehensive state policy	Westall & Cummings (2023)	DiD across states	Grade 4 NAEP reading	4-5 scale-score points
MS 3rd-grade retention	Slungaard Mumma & Winters (2023)	RDD	Grade 6 ELA	>1.0 SD
FL 3rd-grade retention	Schwerdt, West, & Winters (2017)	RDD	Grade 10 reading	Persistently positive at same grade
Systematic phonics	Ehri et al. (2001) / NRP	Meta-analysis	Reading	d = 0.41 (0.55 if K-1)
Structured vs balanced literacy	Multiple (2024-25)	Meta-analysis	Reading	d = 0.44-0.47
Teacher coaching	Kraft, Blazar, & Hogan (2018)	Meta-analysis	Instruction / Achievement	0.49 SD / 0.18 SD

LETRS itself has thinner stand-alone RCT evidence than its market share suggests. A large-scale IES-funded study found LETRS improved teacher knowledge but did not significantly improve student 3rd-grade reading compared to alternative professional development. The Southeast Regional Education Laboratory's Mississippi evaluation found K-3 teacher knowledge rose from the 48th to 59th percentile in one year of LETRS. The reasonable read is that LETRS is an ingredient whose effect depends on coaching, curriculum alignment, and principal support.

3. Federal and State Policy Context

Federal Framework

Mississippi's reforms unfolded inside, but not because of, a federal policy scaffold. The Every Student Succeeds Act (ESSA, 2015) replaced NCLB's 'scientifically based research' standard with a four-tier evidence hierarchy (Strong, Moderate, Promising, Demonstrates Rationale) that now governs Title I Section 1003, Title II, and Title IV spending. Structured literacy programs carry Tier 1 or Tier 2 ratings, insulating them from the evidence-base litigation that dogged Reading First.

The IES/What Works Clearinghouse Practice Guide 'Foundational Skills to Support Reading for Understanding in Kindergarten Through 3rd Grade' (Foorman et al., 2016) is the closest thing to a federal endorsement of structured literacy, with three of four recommendations carrying Strong Evidence ratings. Most state science-of-reading statutes cite it.

The Comprehensive Literacy State Development (CLSD) grant program, authorized under ESSA, awarded roughly $149 million to 22 states and DC in September 2024. Tennessee was among awardees; Mississippi was not, consistent with its primarily state-funded reform model. The Individuals with Disabilities Education Act (IDEA) names dyslexia as a type of Specific Learning Disability but does not

require universal K-3 screening. Approximately 40 states, including Mississippi and Tennessee, exceed the federal minimum.

Civil rights risk around retention is real but unlitigated. Office for Civil Rights (OCR) Civil Rights Data Collection shows Black students retained at 4.2 percent versus 1.5 percent of white students. Title VI disparate-impact enforcement is available administratively through OCR even though Alexander v. Sandoval (2001) foreclosed private lawsuits. No federal court has struck down a 3rd-grade retention law, but advocacy groups have submitted complaints against Florida and Mississippi.

Tennessee Alignment

Tennessee's 2021 Tennessee Literacy Success Act (TLSA; HB 7004/SB 7003) is a near-clone of Mississippi's LBPA passed eight years later. TLSA requires phonics-based instruction, universal K-2 screening three times per year, LETRS-aligned professional development, and a 3rd-grade retention/tutoring pathway. Reading 360, launched under Commissioner Penny Schwinn at $100M+, bundles free high-quality instructional materials (the TN Foundational Skills Curriculum Supplement), TNTP-delivered training, summer programming, and a mentor-district network anchored by Putnam County. TISA (effective July 1, 2023) replaced the 30-year-old BEP with an outcomes-weighted formula that rewards 3rd-grade ELA proficiency directly. Best for All and RTI2 provide the strategic-plan and intervention frameworks.

Tennessee's retention implementation is markedly softer than Mississippi's. Retention rates have stayed under 1 percent despite roughly 60 percent of 3rd graders scoring below proficient, because the law's tutoring pathway and a 2024 'conference pathway' amendment provide wide off-ramps. Critics argue the law has been effectively defanged; defenders argue the tutoring pathway is working as designed and producing the 4th-grade ELA gains observed in 2024.

4. What Works: Implementation Models

Mississippi's Operating System

The Mississippi model is better understood as an operating system than as a single intervention. The load-bearing pieces (ExcelinEd, 2019; Reading League, 2024; BRI):

- Literacy coaches deployed by MDE, not the district. Coaches are on-site at least 85 percent of the school week, split time between two schools, submit monthly reports to Regional Coordinators, and work shoulder-to-shoulder with both teachers and principals.
- LETRS training for 15,000-19,000+ K-3 teachers, delivered over two years (~160 hours).
- Universal K-3 screening three times per year, with Individual Reading Improvement Plans (IRIPs) and mandatory parent notification for students flagged deficient.
- Summer reading camps offering 3-6 weeks of 4-hour days with state-approved phonics-based curriculum, taught by 'effective' or 'highly effective'-rated teachers.

- Third-grade retention gate with Good Cause Exemptions (ELL students with <2 years instruction, IEP students who received 2 years of intensive remediation, prior retainees, or demonstrated proficiency on an alternative assessment). Retention rates stabilized at 8-10 percent.
- Principal-as-instructional-leader training, including the MDE 'Guide and Checklists for a School Leader's Walkthrough During Literacy Instruction,' which is widely cited as underappreciated by replicators.

Mississippi District Snapshots

Cleveland School District (Delta, ~3,100 students, majority-Black, high-poverty) is the most cited success story, with reading proficiency above the state average despite location in one of the poorest counties in the country. Strong BRI coaching presence is credited. Corinth School District (~2,600 students, NE Mississippi) is the nearest Greeneville-size analog, consistently among the highest-performing districts in the state; relies on LBPA supports plus a locally-branded 'Corinth Reads' initiative and disciplined principal walkthroughs. Jackson Public Schools (~20,000, majority-Black, urban high-poverty) is the cautionary tale: 3rd-grade reading proficiency at 26 percent versus 42 percent statewide, with 'Project 75' launched in late 2025 to push 3rd-grade pass rates to 75 percent. DeSoto County (~33,000, suburban) outperforms state averages but with smaller reform-induced gains because it started from a higher base.

Replicator States

Alabama (Literacy Act, 2019; full enforcement 2024) is the closest clone. In 2024, the first year of full enforcement, 3rd-grade ELA proficiency jumped from 53 percent to 62 percent in a single year, and 'below grade level' fell from 17 percent to 9 percent. Fewer than 1 percent of 3rd graders were actually retained, far below the 24 percent projected by pre-testing. Summer camps and exemption pathways explain the gap between projection and enforcement.

Louisiana (Act 108, 2021) layered high-dosage tutoring vouchers on top of the Mississippi playbook. Louisiana is the only state to surpass pre-pandemic NAEP reading by 2024, moving from 42nd to 16th in 4th-grade reading. K-3 reading proficiency climbed to 50 percent by November 2025.

Tennessee (TLSA 2021, Reading 360) is covered in Section 3. The Elizabethton City Schools case is directly transferable to Greeneville: a small East TN city system that piloted the Tennessee Foundational Skills Curriculum Supplement with a 'year of grace' before full-fidelity implementation in 2022-23, producing substantial reductions in Tier 2/3 intervention group size within a year (The 74, 2025).

North Carolina (SB387, 2021) trained 44,000+ K-5 educators in LETRS by June 2024 and hired 115 district-level literacy specialists. DIBELS 8 data showed roughly 69,732 fewer K-3 students below benchmark since 2021-22. Ohio (HB 33, 2023) invested $169M over FY24-25 but posted disappointing early results, with 3rd-grade state-test reading falling from 64.5 to 61.3 percent, a reminder that compliance timelines alone do not produce NAEP-scale movement. Colorado (READ Act, 2012) was an early adopter with a broader screening focus but a narrower retention gate and produced more modest results, underscoring the retention gate's material role in the Mississippi bundle.

Realistic Timelines and What Was Revised

Mississippi's timeline is instructive: LBPA passed in 2013, modest gains by 2015, meaningful NAEP gains by 2019, national-headline gains by 2022. States expecting 1-2 year turnarounds are frustrated. Mississippi itself revised its initial implementation in three ways: expanded the coach corps and added Regional Coordinators for supervision; layered walkthrough protocols and principal training onto initial LETRS to improve fidelity; and strengthened parent-notification and communication protocols for retention. The state did not build a parallel middle-grades literacy infrastructure, and 8th-grade NAEP scores have not tracked 4th-grade gains. States copying the model should plan for middle-grades strategy from day one.

5. Cost-Benefit Analysis

Mississippi's reform is striking not only for NAEP gains but for how cheaply it was bought. State appropriations run about $15 million per year since FY2015 (raised from $9.5M in year one), roughly 0.2 percent of the state budget and approximately $32 per K-3 student per year. ExcelinEd/RMC estimated roughly $111.63 in additional per-pupil implementation spending annually. The single largest anchor investment was private: the $100 million Barksdale Reading Institute gift from 2000.

Cost Components

Line item	Unit cost	Notes
MS state LBPA appropriation	$15M/year (since FY15)	~$32/K-3 pupil; 0.2% of state budget
MS initial LBPA appropriation (2013)	$9.5M	Raised ~60% to $15M in 2014
Barksdale Reading Institute gift (2000)	$100M (private, one-time)	Seeded coaches, Principal Corps
LETRS teacher training	$500-$1,500/teacher	2-year, ~160-hour sequence
Literacy coach (MS, base salary)	~$48,572/year	ZipRecruiter 2026 MS avg
Literacy coach (fully loaded, national)	$75K-$100K/year	Benefits + overhead
Universal screener (FastBridge)	~$8.32/student/year	Volume discounts available
Per-pupil retention cost (extra year)	$10,000-$13,000	Up to $35K in some districts
MS implementation per-pupil add'l	~$111.63/year	RMC/ExcelinEd estimate
TN Reading 360	$100M total	$60M ESSER + $40M federal grant
AL Literacy Act (FY27)	$151.9M	Grew from $45M (2019)
OH Science of Reading (FY24-25)	$169M	$86M PD + $64M curriculum
IN literacy coaching	$111M	One-time investment

Retention is the hidden cost. At roughly 8-10 percent of 3rd graders retained annually in the early years and ~2 percent more recently, each retained student costs Mississippi one extra year of K-12 schooling, estimated nationally at $10,000-$13,000 per pupil. For a typical Mississippi cohort of 3,000-4,000 retainees, that is $33-$44 million in extra schooling costs not captured in the LBPA line item. The Wheelock estimate that retention drives only 22 percent of the treatment effect means Mississippi is paying a meaningful share of its results through a cost not visible in the headline $15M figure.

Return on Investment

The most-cited ROI calculation draws on Hanushek's returns-to-skills framework. Cohorts exposed to LBPA from K-3 gained approximately 0.25 SD in reading, roughly one year of academic progress. Each year of educational attainment raises lifetime earnings about 9 percent, implying a lifetime earnings lift of approximately 2.25 percent (about $1,000 per year for a typical high school graduate). Against the $32 per-pupil annual program cost, the ratio works out to roughly $32 in lifetime earnings gained per $1 spent (The Conversation/Arkansas Advocate, 2025). Hanushek's PIAAC work finds a one-SD numeracy/literacy gain produces an 18 percent wage premium on average (28 percent in the U.S.). These are macro estimates; the Columbia Statistical Modeling critique (December 2025) notes that selection bias from retention would reduce, not eliminate, the underlying ROI.

Peer-state comparisons expose Mississippi's cost efficiency. Tennessee ($100M), Alabama ($151.9M FY27), Ohio ($169M FY24-25), Indiana ($111M), and New York ($10M for 20,000 teachers) all invested more per-pupil than Mississippi, though most were one-time or ESSER-dependent investments with sustainability risk. Mississippi has sustained $15M recurring appropriations for 10+ years, a political durability peer states have not yet proven. The cost advantage depends on Barksdale's private capital, which most states cannot replicate.

6. Criticisms, Limitations, and Risks

Skepticism about the 'Mississippi Miracle' framing is legitimate, growing, and methodologically serious. The defensible skeptical position is not that the gains are fake, but that the magnitude is overstated, the durability is suspect, and the causal attribution is oversold. The most important critiques:

Retention-Driven Selection Bias on NAEP

Because NAEP is administered in spring of 4th grade, students retained in 3rd grade are either still in 3rd grade (excluded) or, when they do appear, are older with an extra year of instruction. Paul Thomas (NEPC) labels this the 'Science of Retention, not the Science of Reading.' A December 2025 Columbia Statistical Modeling analysis estimates retention alone accounts for roughly one-quarter of the observed gain. Defenders counter that Andrew Ho (Harvard) found the average test-taker age changed only 0.01 years from 1998-2013 to 2017, and that the largest NAEP gains occurred between 2013-2015 before retention was fully enforced (Fordham Institute, 2025; The 74, 2024). The most credible synthesis: selection explains some but not most of the gain.

Long-Term Harms of Retention

Jimerson (2001) meta-analyzed 20 retention studies and concluded the practice 'fails to demonstrate greater benefits to students' than promotion. Older literature cites 2-11x increased dropout odds for retained students. Figlio and Ozek (2019) found early retention can boost short- and medium-term achievement but that retention in later grades sharply elevates dropout risk. Mississippi's policy may trade visible 4th-grade score gains for invisible later-life costs.

Equity and Disproportionate Impact

Retention falls heaviest on Black, Hispanic, and low-income students. Michigan's parallel 'Read by Grade Three' law was repealed in March 2023 by Governor Whitmer after Education Week documented disproportionate impact on Black and low-income students without clear academic benefit. Mississippi's own disaggregated data show Black and economically disadvantaged students retained at higher rates, though defenders note Mississippi's Black 4th-graders now outperform Black students in 47 other states on NAEP.

Fade-Out Into Middle School

Westall and Cummings (2023) found retention-linked 4th-grade gains fade by 8th grade across 41 states with early literacy policies. Mississippi's 2024 NAEP illustrates this exactly: tied for 8th in 4th-grade reading, tied for 42nd in 8th-grade reading. Hechinger Report's Proof Points series has repeatedly documented stalled middle-school gains in southern states that boosted early reading.

LETRS Efficacy Questions

A large-scale IES-funded study of LETRS found improved teacher knowledge but no significant student 3rd-grade reading gains compared to alternative PD. Given 160 hours of training over two years at $500-$1,500 per teacher, critics (Gabriel, 2024; Thomas, 2024) question whether the investment is evidence-driven or compliance theater. Self-reported 'practice change' in teacher surveys may capture compliance rather than instructional transformation.

Other Material Critiques

- Ceiling/floor effects and regression to the mean: Mississippi started from such a low baseline that dramatic gains were mechanically easier to achieve.
- MAAP-NAEP alignment: Mississippi overhauled MAAP in 2015 to align more closely with NAEP frameworks, introducing partial test-prep risk.
- Causal attribution: with the LBPA, LETRS, coaching, screening, curriculum overhauls, early childhood investment, and BRI running simultaneously, attributing outcomes to any single lever is unsupported.
- Philanthro-capitalism critique: the Barksdale Foundation's $160M footprint allowed private donors to shape public policy without democratic accountability (McGoey; Mississippi Today, 2025).
- Reading Recovery / structured-literacy debate: Richard Allington and others argue decoding-heavy programs under-emphasize volume of reading, motivation, and appropriate text matching.
- Failed replications: Michigan's retention law was repealed in 2023; Ohio's early returns disappoint; Oklahoma and Missouri face similar implementation risks.

Conflicting Findings

Fordham Institute and The 74 argue the NAEP gains are not a retention mirage, citing Ho's age-stability analysis and the pre-2015 gain timing. The Columbia Statistical Modeling blog and NEPC's Thomas argue selection bias inflates the gain. Spencer (2024) and Westall & Cummings (2023) split the difference, estimating retention at roughly 22 percent of total effect. The most credible reading is that all three positions are partially correct: the gains are real, retention inflates them somewhat, and the instructional bundle drives the majority of the effect.

7. Measurable Outcomes

Outcomes most tightly linked to Mississippi's reforms, ranked by evidence strength:

- Grade 4 NAEP reading: Mississippi moved from 49th (2013) to 29th (2019) to 9th (2024), with the largest long-term gain in the nation. Effect size ~0.14 SD aggregate, rising to ~0.25 SD for K-exposed cohorts. Strong causal evidence.
- Grade 4 state-test (MAAP) reading proficiency: sustained upward trend post-2015 cut-score reset. Caveat: partial NAEP-alignment risk.
- Grade 6 ELA for retained students: >1.0 SD gain in RDD study, driven by Black and Hispanic students (Slungaard Mumma & Winters, 2023). Strong causal evidence, narrow population.
- Grade 8 NAEP reading: no significant improvement. Mississippi ranks tied-for-42nd. Strong evidence against sustained impact.
- Equity gaps: Mississippi's Black 4th-graders now outperform Black students in 47 other states on NAEP, but within-state Black-white and low-income gaps persist. Mixed evidence.
- High school graduation and dropout: no Mississippi-specific causal study. General retention literature raises dropout concerns. Weak, indirect evidence.
- Lifetime earnings: modeled ROI of ~$32 per $1 spent (Hanushek framework). Macro estimate, not directly measured. Weak causal evidence.
- Teacher knowledge of foundational reading: K-3 teachers moved from 48th to 59th percentile in one year of LETRS (REL Southeast). Moderate evidence.

8. Bottom Line

Mississippi's literacy gains are real, substantial, and unusually well-documented for a state-level reform. The 4th-grade NAEP rise from 49th to 9th reflects roughly 0.14 SD of genuine improvement on a nationally-normed assessment, supported by rigorous causal studies (Spencer 2024; Westall & Cummings 2023; Slungaard Mumma & Winters 2023). The 'miracle' framing, however, oversells a decade of grinding, multi-lever work as a replicable silver bullet. Retention mechanically inflates the NAEP headline by roughly one-quarter; gains fade by 8th grade; Black and low-income students bear disproportionate retention burden; and LETRS' stand-alone efficacy is thinner than its market share suggests. None of these concerns falsify the gains, but they materially reshape what a replicator should expect.

For a district leader, the actionable takeaways are narrower than the headlines. First, structured literacy plus job-embedded coaching works over a 5-10 year horizon when implemented with fidelity and principal engagement. Second, the retention gate is a diagnostic pressure point, not the engine; Tennessee's sub-1-percent retention rate shows the off-ramps can work, and Michigan's 2023 repeal shows heavy-handed enforcement is politically fragile. Third, expect the 4th-grade gain, and plan for middle-grades fade. Fourth, compliance-only purchases (curriculum without coaching, LETRS without walkthroughs) produce paper reform without score movement: Ohio's early returns are the current cautionary tale. Fifth, the Barksdale-anchored private capital is not replicable; state appropriations must be politically durable for 10+ years, which is the harder ask.

For Greeneville City Schools specifically, the Corinth (MS) and Elizabethton (TN) analogs are the most transferable. Small-city districts with 4 K-3 elementary schools can realistically support 1-2 shared literacy coaches, a disciplined principal walkthrough protocol using MDE's free 'Guide and Checklists for a School Leader's Walkthrough,' fidelity to the TN Foundational Skills Curriculum Supplement, and summer tutoring partnerships. The state has already funded LETRS-equivalent training through TNTP and the Foundational Skills Supplement; the district does not need to buy curriculum, only enforce fidelity. Expect 3-5 years before TCAP 3rd-grade ELA moves meaningfully and longer before any NAEP-scale signal.

Open questions that the evidence base has not yet resolved: (1) whether the gains from coach-heavy models can be sustained after coach funding sunsets (the BRI model that Mississippi now has to carry alone); (2) how to extend early-grade wins into middle school without the same level of screening and intervention infrastructure; (3) whether lighter-touch retention models like Tennessee's produce the same effect size as Mississippi's stricter enforcement; (4) whether teacher training transfers to student outcomes in the absence of curriculum alignment; and (5) how replicators should weigh the documented equity costs against the measured academic gains.

9. References

All sources consolidated, deduplicated, and sorted alphabetically by first author/organization.

1. Alabama Daily News (2024). *Alabama retains fewer than 1% of third-graders under Literacy Act*. https://aldailynews.com/alabama-retains-fewer-than-1-of-third-graders-under-literacy-act/
2. Alabama Reading Initiative. *Alabama Literacy Act*. https://ari.alsde.edu/alabama-literacy-act-ala
3. Alabama Reflector (2026). *Alabama House committee OKs 2027 education budget*. https://alabamareflector.com/2026/03/12/alabama-house-committee-oks-2027-education-budget-with-pay-raises-level-funding/
4. Aldeman, C. *Mississippi raised the floor and the ceiling*. https://www.chadaldeman.com/p/mississippi-raised-the-floor-and
5. Alliance for Learning Innovation. *How State and Federal R&D Investments Helped Make the 'Mississippi Miracle' Possible*. https://www.alicoalition.org/success-story/how-state-and-federal-rd-investments-helped-make-the-mississippi-miracle-possible/

6. Allington, R. *What Really Matters When Working With Struggling Readers*. https://www.ocmboces.org/tfiles/folder1237/1603_Allington_WRM.RT_.pdf
7. American Library Association (2025). *Bicameral Right to Read Act*. https://www.ala.org/news/2025/12/bicameral-right-read-act-would-boost-federal-investment-literacy-programs-ensure
8. Bush Center. *Mississippi's Reading Revolution*. https://www.bushcenter.org/catalyst/the-fix/mississippis-reading-revolution
9. CCSSO. *States Leading: How SEAs Leveraged Pandemic Relief Funds*. https://learning.ccsso.org/states-leading-how-state-education-agencies-are-leveraging-the-esser-set-aside
10. Chalkbeat (2023). *Mississippi saw big gains on the NAEP. But why?* https://www.chalkbeat.org/2023/7/18/23799124/mississippi-miracle-test-scores-naep-early-literacy-grade-retention-reading-phonics/
11. Chalkbeat Detroit (2023). *Michigan third grade retention repeal*. https://www.chalkbeat.org/detroit/2023/3/7/23629746/michigan-third-grade-retention-reading-repeal-gov-gretchen-whitmer-house/
12. Chalkbeat newsletter. *Has the Mississippi miracle been debunked?* https://cbnewsletters.chalkbeat.org/p/a-debunking-debunked-affordability-and-schools-higher-ed-s-vibecession-and-more
13. Chalkbeat Tennessee (2021). *Tennessee unveils $100 million plan*. https://www.chalkbeat.org/tennessee/2021/1/4/22213875/tennessee-unveils-100-million-plan-to-help-its-youngest-students-read-better/
14. Chalkbeat Tennessee (2024). *Few 3rd/4th graders retained under reading law*. https://www.chalkbeat.org/tennessee/2024/11/22/third-fourth-grade-reading-retention-data-shows-improvements-2024/
15. Chalkbeat Tennessee (2024). *Fourth grade retention policy*. https://www.chalkbeat.org/tennessee/2024/02/16/fourth-grade-retention-policy-to-define-adequate-growth-for-reading-law/
16. Chalkbeat Tennessee (2024). *Retention should start in K, says Tennessee Board of Education*. https://www.chalkbeat.org/tennessee/2024/03/04/third-grade-reading-retention-is-too-late-says-tennessee-board-of-education/
17. Chalkbeat Tennessee (2025). *NAEP: TN students buck national trends*. https://www.chalkbeat.org/tennessee/2025/01/29/naep-students-buck-national-trends-nations-report-card-2024/
18. Chalkbeat Tennessee (2025). *TCAP reading scores released*. https://www.chalkbeat.org/tennessee/2025/07/09/tcap-reading-scores-released-statewide-third-grade-retention-law/
19. Chronicle of Philanthropy. *8 Things a Mega-Donor Did Right to Engineer a Miracle*. https://www.philanthropy.com/news/8-things-a-mega-donor-did-right-to-engineer-a-miracle/
20. Civilization Works. *Science of Reading Reforms in FL, MS, AL, LA, TN*. https://www.civilizationworks.org/cw-master-blog/science-of-reading-reforms-in-florida-mississippi-alabama-louisiana-and-tennessee

21. Congress.gov (2024). *S.3907 - Literacy Improvement for Transformation Act*. https://www.congress.gov/bill/118th-congress/senate-bill/3907/text
22. Congressional Research Service. *Race Discrimination at School: Title VI and OCR* (IF12455). https://www.congress.gov/crs-product/IF12455
23. CTAS. *TISA Overview*. https://www.ctas.tennessee.edu/eli/tennessee-investment-student-achievement-tisa
24. Drum, K. *Mississippi reading isn't so miraculous after all*. https://jabberwocking.com/update-mississippi-reading-isnt-so-miraculous-after-all/
25. EdAdvocate. *Pass or Fail: The Real Cost of Student Retention*. https://www.theedadvocate.org/pass-fail-real-cost-student-retention/
26. EdNC (2024). *North Carolina teachers finish SoR training*. https://www.ednc.org/06-05-2024-north-carolina-teachers-finish-science-of-reading-training-dpi-says/
27. EdSurge (2025). *Louisiana's NAEP Score: A Victory for the Science of Reading*. https://www.edsurge.com/news/2025-02-25-louisiana-s-naep-score-a-victory-for-the-science-of-reading
28. EdTrust-TN. *Response to 2024 NAEP Scores*. https://edtrusttn.org/official-statement/edtrust-tennessee-responds-to-2024-naep-scores/
29. Education Week (2012). *Civil Rights Data Show Retention Disparities*. https://www.edweek.org/leadership/civil-rights-data-show-retention-disparities/2012/03
30. Education Week (2012). *Retention Costs More, Accomplishes Less*. https://www.edweek.org/education/opinion-retention-costs-more-accomplishes-less/2012/02
31. Education Week (2023). *3rd Grade Reading Retention: Why the Research Is Complicated*. https://www.edweek.org/teaching-learning/3rd-grade-reading-retention-why-the-research-is-complicated/2023/08
32. Education Week (2023). *Michigan's 3rd Grade Retention Law Held Back More Black and Low-Income Students*. https://www.edweek.org/teaching-learning/michigans-3rd-grade-retention-law-held-back-more-black-and-low-income-students/2023/04
33. Education Week. *What Is LETRS? Why One Training Is Dominating Science of Reading Efforts*. https://www.edweek.org/teaching-learning/letrs-program-teacher-training
34. Ehri, L. C., Nunes, S. R., Stahl, S. A., & Willows, D. M. (2001). *Systematic Phonics Instruction Helps Students Learn to Read*. Review of Educational Research, 71(3). https://journals.sagepub.com/doi/10.3102/00346543071003393
35. ExcelinEd (2019). *Mississippi's Literacy-Based Promotion Act: An Inside Look*. https://www.excelined.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/03/ExcelinEd.MSGatewaytoSuccess.March2019.pdf
36. ExcelinEd (2022). *How Mississippi Reformed Reading Instruction*. https://excelined.org/2022/12/02/how-mississippi-reformed-reading-instruction/
37. ExcelinEd (2023). *Effect of Retention Under MS Test-Based Policy* (Policy Brief). https://excelined.org/wp-content/uploads/2023/02/WEPC_MSRetentionPolicyBrief_2023.pdf
38. ExcelinEd (2023). *Four Reasons Mississippi's Reading Gains Are Neither Myth Nor Miracle*. https://excelined.org/2023/08/11/four-reasons-why-mississippis-reading-gains-are-neither-myth-nor-miracle/

39. ExcelinEd (2025). *Policy Lessons from States That Improved Proficiency*. https://excelined.org/2025/03/04/policy-lessons-from-states-that-improved-students-reading-and-math-proficiency/
40. ExcelinEd in Action (2025). *The Science of Reading: 15 States Strengthen Early Literacy Policy in 2024*. https://excelinedinaction.org/2025/01/07/the-science-of-reading-15-states-strengthen-early-literacy-policy-in-2024/
41. Federal Register (2024). *Applications for New Awards; Comprehensive Literacy State Development*. https://www.federalregister.gov/documents/2024/04/23/2024-08578/applications-for-new-awards-comprehensive-literacy-state-development
42. Fick. *Impact of MS K-3 Literacy Initiative PD* (dissertation). https://aquila.usm.edu/dissertations/1932/
43. Figlio & Ozek (RAND working paper). *Retention and high school outcomes*. https://www.rand.org/content/dam/rand/pubs/working_papers/WR1200/WR1259/RAND_WR1259.pdf
44. Figlio, D., & Ozek, U. (2024). *The Effects of Retention in the Third Grade on Student Outcomes*. https://edworkingpapers.com/sites/default/files/ai22-688.pdf
45. Foorman, B. et al. / IES (2016). *Foundational Skills to Support Reading for Understanding in K-3*. https://ies.ed.gov/ncee/wwc/practiceguide/21
46. Fordham Institute (2023). *Assessing the federal Striving Readers grant program*. https://fordhaminstitute.org/national/commentary/assessing-federal-striving-readers-grant-program
47. Fordham Institute (2025). *The Mississippi Miracle Wasn't a Retention-Policy Mirage*. https://fordhaminstitute.org/national/commentary/mississippi-miracle-wasnt-retention-policy-mirage
48. Fordham Institute. *Mississippi Rising? A partial explanation*. https://fordhaminstitute.org/national/commentary/mississippi-rising-partial-explanation-its-naep-improvement-it-holds-students
49. Fordham Institute. *Off and Running: Ohio's early SoR implementation*. https://fordhaminstitute.org/ohio/research/and-running-ohios-early-implementation-its-science-reading-reforms
50. Fordham Institute. *Ohio's Path on Early Literacy*. https://fordhaminstitute.org/ohio/research/ohios-path-early-literacy-science-reading-progress-and-challenges
51. Fordham Institute. *Redefining the federal role in literacy*. https://fordhaminstitute.org/national/commentary/redefining-federal-role-literacy-strengthening-grants-drive-statewide-reform
52. Foundational Skills meta-analysis (2022). *Foundational Skills and Reading Comprehension*. https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC9683349/
53. Gabriel, R. *Contracting with LETRS has always meant ignoring evidence*. https://rachaelreadingpolicy.substack.com/p/contracting-with-letrs-has-always
54. Galbally et al. (2025). *(Not so) universal literacy screening*. Annals of Dyslexia. https://link.springer.com/article/10.1007/s11881-025-00342-1

55. Gelman, A. (2025). *How much of Mississippi's education miracle is selection bias?* https://statmodeling.stat.columbia.edu/2025/12/01/how-much-of-mississippis-education-miracle-is-an-artifact-of-selection-bias/
56. Gelman, A. (2026). *Last post on estimated effects of Mississippi school reforms*. https://statmodeling.stat.columbia.edu/2026/01/05/last-post-on-the-estimated-effects-of-mississippi-school-reforms/
57. GovInfo (2025). *Right to Read Act of 2025 (S.3365 summary)*. https://www.govinfo.gov/bulkdata/BILLSUM/119/s/BILLSUM-119s3365.xml
58. Greene, J. P., & Winters, M. A. (2007, 2012). *Revisiting Grade Retention: Florida Test-Based Promotion*. https://www.researchgate.net/publication/247712733
59. Greeneville City Schools. *Record TCAP Gains*. https://www4.gcschools.net/article/2303995
60. Hanushek, Schwerdt, Wiederhold & Woessmann (2015). *Returns to Skills Around the World: Evidence from PIAAC*. EER. https://hanushek.stanford.edu/sites/default/files/publications/Hanushek+Schwerdt+Wiederhold+Woessmann%202015%20EER%2073.pdf
61. Harvard GSE. *What Mississippi Got Right About Reading*. https://www.gse.harvard.edu/ideas/edcast/26/03/what-mississippi-got-right-about-reading
62. Hechinger Report. *Can literacy coaches help solve Mississippi's education woes?* https://hechingerreport.org/can-literacy-coaches-help-solve-mississippis-education-woes/
63. Hechinger Report. *Lessons from Mississippi: Is there really a miracle?* https://hechingerreport.org/opinion-lessons-from-mississippi-is-there-really-a-miracle-here-we-can-all-learn-from/
64. Hechinger Report. *MS Summer Reading Camps*. https://hechingerreport.org/for-many-mississippi-students-summer-meant-one-last-chance-to-be-promoted-to-fourth-grade/
65. Hechinger Report. *Southern states boost early reading, but gains stall in middle school*. https://hechingerreport.org/proof-points-8th-grade-reading/
66. Institute of Education Sciences. *WWC - ESSA Tiers of Evidence*. https://ies.ed.gov/ncee/wwc/essa
67. International Dyslexia Association. *Universal Screening: K-2 Reading*. https://dyslexiaida.org/universal-screening-k-2-reading/
68. Jimerson, S. R. (2001). *Meta-analysis of grade retention research*. School Psychology Review. https://www.tandfonline.com/doi/abs/10.1080/02796015.2001.12086124
69. Kraft, M. A., Blazar, D., & Hogan, D. (2018). *Teacher Coaching Meta-Analysis*. Review of Educational Research. https://scholar.harvard.edu/files/mkraft/files/kraft_blazar_hogan_2018_teacher_coaching.pdf
70. Legiscan. *Mississippi SB2347 (2013)*. https://legiscan.com/MS/text/SB2347/id/818137
71. Lexia Learning. *ESSA Ratings: Evidence-Based Reading Intervention Programs*. https://www.lexialearning.com/blog/essa-ratings-evidence-based-reading-intervention-programs
72. Lexia Learning. *LETRS training and support services*. https://www.lexialearning.com/letrs/training-and-support-services
73. Lexia Learning. *Mississippi LETRS rollout*. https://www.lexialearning.com/mississippi-letrs

74. Louisiana Department of Education (2025). *LA K-3 Reading Proficiency Climbs to 50%*. https://doe.louisiana.gov/about/newsroom/news-releases/release/2025/11/12/louisiana-k-3-reading-proficiency-climbs-to-50-percent
75. Magnolia Tribune (2022). *Barksdale Reading Institute closes its doors*. https://magnoliatribune.com/2022/06/13/barksdale-reading-institute-closes-its-doors-after-more-than-two-decades-of-early-literacy-work-in-mississippi/
76. Mariano, L. T., & Martorell, P. (2013). *Academic Effects of Summer Instruction and Retention in NYC*. EEPA. https://journals.sagepub.com/doi/10.3102/0162373712454327
77. MDE. *Good Cause Exemption Determination and Documentation Packet*. https://www.mdek12.org/sites/default/files/documents/OAE/Literacy/ResourcesForAdmin/good-cause-exemption-determination-and-documentation-packet-1_20170411085602_42876.pdf
78. MDE. *Literacy Coach Job Description*. https://www.mdek12.org/sites/default/files/Offices/MDE/OAE/OEER/Literacy/LBPA/literacy-coach-job-description-1-5-2017_20170105103918_435280.pdf
79. MDE. *Literacy-Based Promotion Act page*. https://mdek12.org/literacy/lbpa/
80. MDE. *MS LBPA FAQ*. https://www.mdek12.org/sites/default/files/Offices/MDE/OA/OSA/LPBA/lbpa_faq_new_format_final.pdf
81. Minding the Campus (2025). *The Mississippi Miracle Needs a Reality Check*. https://mindingthecampus.org/2025/06/26/the-mississippi-miracle-needs-a-reality-check/
82. Mississippi Early Literacy Matters (2024). *Mississippi Implementation Report*. https://earlyliteracymatters.org/wp-content/uploads/2024/02/Mississippi_ImplementationReport_Final_.pdf
83. Mississippi First (2024). *Literacy Series: Pre- and Post-Pandemic Achievement in Mississippi*. https://www.mississippifirst.org/literacy-series-part-1/
84. Mississippi First. *Contextualizing Mississippi's 2024 NAEP Scores*. https://www.mississippifirst.org/contextualizing-mississippis-2024-naep-scores/
85. Mississippi Today (2025). *How Jim Barksdale's $100M gift became 'Mississippi Miracle'*. https://mississippitoday.org/2025/01/24/jim-barksdale-100-million-miracle/
86. Mississippi Today (2025). *Jim Barksdale's $100M changed Mississippi public education*. https://mississippitoday.org/2025/01/26/jim-barksdale-gift-public-schools/
87. Mississippi Today (2025). *JPS Project 75*. https://mississippitoday.org/2025/12/04/jps-third-grade-reading-plan/
88. Moats, L. *LETRS program materials and background*. https://louisamoats.com/
89. National Reading Panel / NICHD (2000). *Teaching Children to Read*. https://www.nichd.nih.gov/publications/pubs/nrp/findings
90. NC DPI (2024). *44,000+ Educators Complete SoR PD*. https://www.dpi.nc.gov/news/press-releases/2024/06/04/over-44000-elementary-educators-master-science-reading-professional-development
91. NCES. *NAEP Long-Term Trend Assessment Results*. https://www.nationsreportcard.gov/highlights/ltt/2022/

92. NEPC. *Policy brief on Science of Reading movement* (Thomas). https://nepc.colorado.edu/sites/default/files/publications/PB%20Thomas_0.pdf
93. NPR (2025). *Louisiana Readers Thriving*. https://www.npr.org/2025/03/13/nx-s1-5304415/louisiana-reading
94. PARCA. *Alabama Literacy Act 2024 Results*. https://parcalabama.org/english-scores-jump-with-full-implementation-of-literacy-act-math-and-science-mixed-results/
95. Petrilli, M. / Fordham (2025). *The Mississippi Miracle wasn't a retention-policy mirage*. https://fordhaminstitute.org/national/commentary/mississippi-miracle-wasnt-retention-policy-mirage
96. Publishing Perspectives (2025). *U.S. Congress Members Reintroduce Federal Right to Read Act*. https://publishingperspectives.com/2025/12/u-s-congress-members-reintroduce-federal-right-to-read-act/
97. Radical Scholarship / Thomas (2025). *Misunderstanding Mississippi's Reading Reform*. https://radicalscholarship.com/2025/09/27/misunderstanding-mississippis-reading-reform-the-need-to-resist-copycat-education-reform/
98. Ravitch, D. (2025). *Oklahoma Legislators Want to Copy the Mississippi Miracle*. https://dianeravitch.net/2025/11/12/oklahoma-legislators-want-to-copy-the-mississippi-miracle-by-retaining-3rd-graders/
99. Reading League (2024). *The Long View of Literacy in Mississippi*. https://www.thereadingleague.org/wp-content/uploads/2024/10/Changing-Course-Article-for-EAC.pdf
100. Reading League Compass. *Policymakers and SEAs - Mississippi*. https://www.thereadingleague.org/compass/policymakers-and-state-education-agencies/mississippi/
101. Reading Universe. *Barksdale Reading Institute: The Mississippi Story*. https://readinguniverse.org/resources/video/big-picture/barksdale-reading-institute-the-mississippi-story
102. Results for America (2016). *The Evidence Provisions of ESSA*. https://results4america.org/wp-content/uploads/2016/11/ESSA-evidence-provisions-explainer-7.22.16-Update.pdf
103. RMC Research Corporation (2019). *Mississippi's LBPA: An Inside Look*. ERIC ED613758. https://eric.ed.gov/?id=ED613758
104. Schwerdt, G., West, M. R., & Winters, M. A. (2017). *Test-based retention effects in Florida*. NBER w21509. https://www.nber.org/system/files/working_papers/w21509/revisions/w21509.rev0.pdf
105. Slungaard Mumma, K., & Winters, M. A. (2023). *The Effect of Retention Under Mississippi's Test-Based Promotion Policy*. Wheelock WP. https://wheelockpolicycenter.org/wp-content/uploads/2023/02/MississippiRetention_WP.pdf
106. Spencer, N. (2024). *Comprehensive early literacy policy and the Mississippi Miracle*. EER. https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/abs/pii/S027277572400092X
107. SREB. *Effectiveness of Early Literacy Policies*. https://www.sreb.org/post/effectiveness-early-literacy-policies-when-statewide-efforts-support-them

108. Structured vs. balanced literacy meta-analysis (2024). https://www.researchgate.net/publication/387497935_Structured_Literacy_Compared_to_Balanced_Literacy_A_meta-analysis
109. TDOE. *2023-24 3rd/4th Grade ELA TCAP Results*. https://www.tn.gov/education/news/2024/6/13/tdoe-releases-2023-24-3rd-grade-and-4th-grade-ela-tcap-state-level-results.html
110. TDOE. *2024 NAEP TN Results Overview*. https://www.tn.gov/content/dam/tn/education/documents/2024_NAEP_TN_Results_Overview.pdf
111. TDOE. *Nation's Report Card Shows Meaningful Academic Gains*. https://www.tn.gov/education/news/2025/1/29/nation-s-report-card-shows-meaningful-academic-gains-as-a-result-of-tennessee-s-commitment-to-public-schools-.html
112. TDOE. *Reading 360*. https://www.tn.gov/education/reading-360.html
113. TDOE. *Tennessee Foundational Skills Curriculum Supplement*. https://bestforall.tnedu.gov/lessons-and-learning-item?content-id=7252
114. TDOE. *Year-Over-Year Improvement Across All Subject Areas*. https://www.tn.gov/education/news/2025/7/8/tdoe-announces-year-over-year-improvement-across-all-subject-areas.html
115. Tennessee Comptroller. *Tennessee Literacy Success Act*. https://comptroller.tn.gov/office-functions/research-and-education-accountability/prek-12-collection/literacy-success-act--lsa-.html
116. The 74 Million (2024). *There Really Was a 'Mississippi Miracle' in Reading*. https://www.the74million.org/article/there-really-was-a-mississippi-miracle-in-reading-states-should-learn-from-it/
117. The 74 Million (2025). *Curriculum Case Study: Elizabethton TN*. https://www.the74million.org/article/curriculum-case-study-how-grade-level-literacy-doubled-in-just-2-months-in-a-rural-tennessee-district/
118. The 74 Million. *Disappointing: Ohio's Science of Reading Switch Not Yet Bringing Results*. https://www.the74million.org/article/disappointing-ohios-science-of-reading-switch-not-yet-bringing-results/
119. The Conversation / Arkansas Advocate (2025). *Mississippi's education miracle*. https://arkansasadvocate.com/2025/03/27/mississippis-education-miracle-a-model-for-global-literacy-reform/
120. Thomas, P. L. (NEPC). *Science of Reading or Science of Retention?* https://nepc.colorado.edu/blog/science-reading-or-science-retention
121. Thomas, P. L. (NEPC). *Third Grade Retention: The Fool's Gold of Reading Reform*. https://nepc.colorado.edu/blog/third-grade-retention
122. TN Comptroller. *Tennessee Literacy Success Act (TLSA)*. https://comptroller.tn.gov/office-functions/research-and-education-accountability/prek-12-collection/literacy-success-act--lsa-.html
123. TN SCORE. *2025 TCAP Data Is Our Compass*. https://tnscore.org/perspectives-and-press/perspectives/2025-tcap-data-our-compass-for-the-work-ahead
124. TN SCORE. *Understanding 2024 TCAP Results*. https://tnscore.org/perspectives-and-press/perspectives/understanding-2024-tcap-results-five-key-takeaways

125. TNTP. *A Model of Literacy Policy and Practice in Tennessee*. https://tntp.org/case-study/a-model-of-literacy-policy-and-practice-in-tennessee/
126. Tultican blog (2025). *Questioning the Mississippi Miracle Again*. https://tultican.com/2025/03/21/questioning-the-mississippi-miracle-again/
127. U.S. Department of Education / IES. *Did the SRCL Grant Program Reach Its Goals?* https://ies.ed.gov/use-work/resource-library/report/evaluation-report/did-striving-readers-comprehensive-literacy-grant-program-reach-its-goals-implementation-report
128. U.S. Department of Education. *Civil Rights Data Collection*. https://www.ed.gov/laws-and-policy/civil-rights-laws/civil-rights-data-collection-crdc
129. U.S. Department of Education. *Education and Title VI*. https://www.ed.gov/laws-and-policy/civil-rights-laws/race-color-and-national-origin-discrimination/education-and-title-vi
130. Understood.org. *Dyslexia laws: What they are and how they work*. https://www.understood.org/en/articles/dyslexia-laws-what-they-are-and-how-they-work
131. UT Tennessee Reading Research Center (2024). *Patterns of Adopting HQIMs*. https://trrc.utk.edu/wp-content/uploads/2024/09/Patterns-of-Adopting-HQIMs-for-Teaching-Reading-in-TN-Report.pdf
132. Westall, J., & Cummings, A. (2023). *The Effects of Early Literacy Policies on Student Achievement*. SSRN. https://papers.ssrn.com/sol3/papers.cfm?abstract_id=4427675
133. ZipRecruiter (2026). *Literacy Coach Salary by State*. https://www.ziprecruiter.com/Salaries/What-Is-the-Average-Literacy-Coach-Salary-by-State

Appendix A: Tennessee Data

Table A1: Tennessee NAEP and TCAP Trends

Metric	2019	2022	2024/25	Direction
NAEP G4 Reading, avg scale score	~219	217	219	Flat vs 2019; +2 vs 2022
NAEP G4 Reading, national rank	31st	35th	23rd	Up 12 spots
NAEP G4 Reading, % Proficient or above	~30%	~30%	32%	+2 pts (nation 30%)
TCAP G3 ELA % Proficient	~33%	36%	41.7% (2025)	+8.7 pts
TCAP G4 ELA % Proficient	~33%	~36%	~49% (2024)	+16 pts
TCAP G3-8 ELA % Proficient	33.8%	36.5%	42.2% (2025)	+8.4 pts

Table A2: Tennessee vs Mississippi Side-by-Side

Dimension	Tennessee	Mississippi

Signature law	TLSA (2021)	Literacy-Based Promotion Act (2013)
Retention implementation year	2023	2014-15
NAEP G4 Reading 2024 scale score	219	219
NAEP G4 rank 2024	23rd	9th (demog. adj: 1st)
Long-term NAEP gain (2013-2024)	Modest	#1 in nation
3rd grade retention rate (recent)	<1%	~8-9% early; ~2% recent
Teacher PD anchor	TNTP + TN modules	LETRS (universal)
HQIM approach	State list + free supplement	State-adopted + coaching
Funding formula	TISA (2023) with outcomes weights	MAEP (legacy)

Table A3: Tennessee District Exemplars (ELA Proficiency)

District	Approximate Enrollment	G3-8 ELA Proficient	Notes
Johnson City Schools	~7,700	~59.1%	Top 10% of TN; read-to-be-ready grants
Greeneville City Schools	~2,500	48.6% (2024); 49.0% (2025)	+10 pts above state avg
Kingsport City Schools	~7,000	~47.7%	Regional peer
Bristol TN Schools	~3,800	~44%	Regional peer
Putnam County Schools	~12,000	Mentor district	Reading 360 mentor; CKLA adoption
Bradley County Schools	~10,500	+28% 2019-2022	TDOE recovery exemplar
State average	-	42.2% (2025)	-